

Checklist:

Product Strategy Checklist

1. Establish strategic context

- ☐ Clarify the company's mission, objectives, and scorecard
- ☐ Define or confirm product vision and principles
- ☐ Ensure teams understand the broader business context
- ☐ Confirm that team topology and ownership are clear

2. Create a real product strategy

- ☐ Define the few critical problems the business most needs to solve
- ☐ Make explicit choices about what matters most
- ☐ Identify what will **not** be prioritized
- ☐ Avoid confusing strategy with roadmaps, features, or tactics
- ☐ Frame strategy as the approach for achieving the goal

3. Focus on the vital few

- ☐ Reduce the number of active top priorities
- ☐ Limit major initiatives to a manageable number
- ☐ Check whether teams are spread too thin
- ☐ Ensure attention is concentrated on the highest-impact problems
- ☐ Revisit whether the current work is creating outcomes or just activity

4. Generate insights before choosing solutions

- ☐ Study product and business data
- ☐ Analyze acquisition, retention, funnel, and sales patterns
- ☐ Conduct regular user research
- ☐ Look for both evaluative and generative insights
- ☐ Explore enabling technologies that could unlock new solutions
- ☐ Track industry, competitive, and adjacent-market trends
- ☐ Gather insights from multiple sources, not just dashboards
- ☐ Prepare enough context so that important insights are recognizable

5. Share insights across the organization

- ☐ Aggregate learnings from teams regularly
- ☐ Share the most important insights with leaders and peers
- ☐ Ensure insights reach the people making strategic decisions
- ☐ Connect related learnings across teams
- ☐ Avoid letting insights remain isolated within one team

6. Turn insights into action

- ☐ Convert key insights into clear team objectives
- ☐ Give teams problems to solve, not just features to ship
- ☐ Define expected business or customer outcomes
- ☐ Use OKRs or similar methods only if they support empowered teams
- ☐ Provide constraints and context without prescribing every solution
- ☐ Check whether teams are acting like owners, not order-takers

7. Support empowered product teams

- ☐ Confirm each team understands the objective and why it matters
- ☐ Give teams room to discover and deliver the best solution
- ☐ Ensure teams have the right skills, people, and access
- ☐ Avoid stakeholder-driven feature overload
- ☐ Distinguish between serving the business and serving customers in ways that work for the business

8. Practice active management

- ☐ Hold regular 1:1s or coaching sessions with product leaders
- ☐ Review progress weekly or biweekly
- ☐ Surface blockers, dependencies, and risks early
- ☐ Remove obstacles and barriers quickly
- ☐ Help teams make stakeholder decisions when needed
- ☐ Provide help without slipping into command-and-control
- ☐ Track whether teams are actually moving objectives forward

9. Stay adaptive

- ☐ Expect strategy to meet real-world obstacles
- ☐ Watch for missed dependencies, missing capabilities, or urgent issues

- ☐ Reassess priorities when reality changes
- ☐ Be open to vision pivots when a larger opportunity becomes clear
- ☐ Do not abandon the vision too quickly just because execution is hard

10. Final health check

- ☐ We have a small number of truly important priorities
- ☐ We are using insights, not opinions alone
- ☐ Teams are solving problems, not just delivering backlog items
- ☐ Leadership is actively managing progress and removing impediments
- ☐ Work is aligned to measurable outcomes
- ☐ Our strategy reflects choice, thinking, and effort